

timely access to primary care, which can treat medical problems in their early stages and encourage a holistic view of health; and on strengthening health education, which must train a larger workforce to apply advanced methods of promoting healthy living.

Over the years, my international work in healthcare has made it clear that even developed countries have yet to find the right model to ensure the effective delivery of healthcare services. This is because of the type of care required for a variety of lifestyle-related and chronic diseases; the limited capacity to provide care to various classes of society; and the lack of mechanisms to ensure timely access to medical treatment. Preventing diseases before they can take hold, or identifying illnesses in their early stages, are essential factors in achieving successful health outcomes.

Since India is still developing its healthcare system, it can learn from and avoid the costly errors that have been made by developed economies. Moreover, India has the opportunity to create its own unique models that draw upon the strength of every sector: the organisational prowess, entrepreneurial zeal and philanthropic commitment of the private sector; the compassionate character of civil society; the polity's commitment to equity; and the reach and resources of the non-profit sector. I strongly believe that the coming together of these stakeholder groups could transform India's healthcare system, helping India overcome its intractable healthcare challenge. The successes achieved by the National Rural Health Mission—which has begun to bring about significant improvements—illustrate how well-designed programmes can help strengthen the delivery of high-quality healthcare and improve the health status of those who had long been under-served.

The genesis of the Public Health Foundation of India (PHFI), which I helped organise, rests on this belief. An autonomous entity, the PHFI is a unique partnership in which the Government, the private sector, civil society and non-profit bodies have made a commitment to a three-fold charter. The foundation is committed to starting five to

seven public health schools to augment the capacity of public health professionals, who are key to promoting preventive care; to establishing accreditation standards in public health education; and in conducting policy-shaping research. Within the next few years, the PHFI aims to address the severe shortfall of thousands of public health professionals in the country, and in producing more than 10,000 trained professionals every year, in addition to those trained by existing institutes. Improving healthcare capacity requires a renewed focus on advanced techniques, and on a holistic approach that focuses on preventive and promotive strategies. Encouraging wellness is pivotal to the PHFI's design. That approach recognises that, in lower-income countries in particular, it is essential to create cost-effective systems that prevent disease, or that treat it before illnesses become an intense threat.

Another example of a unique public-private partnership in Indian healthcare is the establishment of the Health Management and Research Institute (HMRI) and the Emergency Management and Research Institute (EMRI)—both set up in partnership with the Andhra Pradesh Government. These institutes focus on using advanced technologies to deliver more cost-effective health solutions. They also illustrate the importance of applying "leapfrog technologies" that use the latest developments to improve healthcare delivery. HMRI is a not-for-profit organisation that

focuses on promoting public-health systems by leveraging information, communication technologies and management practices. HMRI supports public-health systems run by the government to provide better access to high-quality services for the vulnerable sectors of society while EMRI provides assistance in fire, police and medical emergencies. It currently operates more than 500 ambulances, with a staff of more than 3,500 people, and covers 80 per cent of the state. These partnerships show how advanced technologies can help deliver our healthcare resources to a wider segment of our society.

It is encouraging to see that additional examples of public-private partnerships are underway in the states of Rajasthan, West



HEMANT CHAWLA

Giant strides: Robotic surgery in progress at Escorts Hospital in Delhi

31,000

**GRADUATES ARE
PRODUCED EVERY
YEAR BY INDIA'S
271 MEDICAL
INSTITUTIONS.**